commented the Pundit **jocularly**, sure that the poor woman would hardly understand the import of his wise observation.

"Well, sir, nobody had told me that!" said Moti in a murmur.

"That is secret !" said the Pundit once again jocularly.

" Who but a **pious** and great sage like you could ever know such secrets! Thank you sir for passing it on to me," said Moti.

The Pundit could not check himself from bursting into a loud **guffaw** at the woman's **naivety**.

Days passed. The period of the Pundit's vow came to an end. He told the milkmaid, "Moti, I must say that you have served me ever well. I appreciate the pain you took in getting up in the small hours and milking the cow and delivering the milk to me at **dawn**. I bless you!"

Moti bowed to him. "So, sir, from tomorrow I report as before, soon after the sunrise; is that all right?"

"Fine," said the Pundit. And then he remembered the boatman. "Moti!" he said, "Tell the boatman how pleased I am with him."

"But, sir, I never bothered him, knowing that he could not come that early!" said Moti.

"Who then plied the boat for you?"

"Boat? Why Sir? I did not need any boat!"

"How then did you cross the river?"

"Good God!" muttered Moti. "You, who can remember hundreds of pages of scriptures, forgot the secret you passed on to me the other day?"

"What do you mean?" asked the Pundit, **intrigued**.

"I just utter the name of Vishnu and walk across the river!

The water remains ankle-deep for me!"

"Ankle-Deep? But isn't the river in spate? Isn't it fact that even in the hottest summer there is enough water in the river for boats to ply?" asked the Pundit.

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